

AI and Employment: What the Evidence Can and Cannot Tell Us

Day 3: Comparing Evidence and Drawing Conclusions

Purpose. Distinguish predictions about what AI could do from evidence about how it is actually being used and how labor markets are changing. Compare what each reading shows, what remains uncertain, and what additional evidence would make its conclusions more convincing.

Warm-Up: One Occupation, Five Tasks (8 minutes)

Your team receives one occupation: junior software developer, customer-support representative, financial analyst, legal associate, marketing specialist, policy analyst, accountant, or software engineer.

List five important tasks performed in that occupation. For each task, classify current AI use as primarily:

- **augmentation:** AI helps a worker perform the task;
- **automation:** AI performs most of the task with limited human involvement; or
- **limited:** current AI systems provide little reliable assistance.

Then answer: Why does the ability of AI to perform some tasks not automatically imply that employment in the occupation will decline?

Evidence Matrix (20 minutes)

Use the ILO report, *Canaries in the Coal Mine?*, the EIG critique, Humlum and Vestergaard, and the Stanford authors' reply.

Claim or step in the chain	What evidence do the readings provide?	What conclusion does the evidence support?	What remains uncertain?
Prediction and capability			
Occupational exposure			
Actual AI adoption			
Worker productivity			
Entry-level hiring			
Employment levels			
Wages and hours			

Do not force every reading into every row. Some studies address only one or two parts of the chain.

Making the Evidence More Convincing (12 minutes)

Consider the claim:

AI adoption has caused a decline in entry-level employment.

Suggest one additional test or source of data that would help researchers evaluate this claim more convincingly. Address the following questions:

- **Actual AI use:** How could researchers determine whether firms or workers are really using AI, rather than relying only on estimates of occupational exposure?
- **Outcome:** What should they measure—job postings, hiring, employment, wages, hours, task content, or promotion?
- **Comparison:** Which workers, firms, occupations, industries, or locations would provide a useful comparison?
- **Timing:** What information is needed from before and after AI adoption?
- **Other explanations:** Could interest rates, sectoral downturns, remote work, outsourcing, or post-pandemic adjustment explain the same pattern?
- **Limits:** What would remain unknown even after conducting the proposed test?

Two-Minute Briefing

State your team's best current conclusion in the following form:

"The evidence supports _____, but does not yet establish _____.
The most valuable additional evidence would be _____."